infrastructure, investment, scientific education, and maritime governance. [44] Meanwhile, the Malabar naval exercises among the Quad countries became more regular and sophisticated and various other mini-lateral and Quad-plus groupings proliferated on an issue-by-issue basis.

Bilateral relations between India and other Quad countries also expanded, especially with Australia after the re-election of Scott Morrison in 2019 and with Japan under Shinzo Abe and his successors. With the United States, India's cooperation extended to a special initiative on Critical and Emerging Technologies (iCET) led by the National Security Advisers, which advanced practical cooperation on defence, space, semiconductors, 5G telecommunications, and biotechnologies, among other areas. [45] During Modi's state visit to the United States in 2023, a number of major defence agreements were unveiled, along with India's joining US-led groupings on critical minerals and space cooperation. [46] Deteriorating ties with China also had important domestic defence implications in India: it helped accelerate procurement of critical kit, helped consolidate the position of the Chief of Defence Staff, and further strengthened the National Security Council Secretariat.

The third major geopolitical shock came over a year and a half after Galwan. Russia—after a major military build-up east of Ukraine and in Belarus in late 2021—initiated a 'special military operation' in late February 2022. Although it had intervened through proxies in the Donbass in eastern Ukraine to control large portions of Luhansk and Donetsk *oblasts*, and annexed Crimea in 2014, the 2022 invasion was on a massive scale. Russian forces entered from Belarus and attempted to seize Hostomel airport outside the Ukrainian capital Kyiv. It also made ingresses in eastern Ukraine and in the south from Crimea. While the northern axis to Kyiv failed to take the capital and the eastern axis made limited progress, Russia made surprising gains in the south to take over much of two additional oblasts. Moscow's objectives to decapitate the leadership in Kyiv and incorporate Ukraine into a larger Russian-led union failed. But after setbacks in the Kharkiv sector in late 2022, the front stabilized and Russia's military industrial superiority shifted leverage in its favour.